



UNSW
SYDNEY

MATH2601 – Higher Linear Algebra

Topic 3 – Linear transformations

Lecture 3.2 – Linear transformations as matrices

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Matrix multiplication as a linear map

Recall that for any matrix $A \in M_{p,q}(\mathbb{F})$, the mapping $T_A : \mathbb{F}^q \rightarrow \mathbb{F}^p$ given by $T_A(\mathbf{v}) = A\mathbf{v}$ for all $\mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{F}^q$ is a linear transformation.

We can use this correspondence to translate properties of linear transformations to properties of matrices. In particular, we can define $\ker(A) = \ker(T_A)$ and $\text{im}(A) = \text{im}(T_A)$, as well as $\text{nullity}(A) = \text{nullity}(T_A)$ and $\text{rank}(A) = \text{rank}(T_A)$.

Definition. The **column space** of a matrix $A \in M_{p,q}(\mathbb{F})$ is the space spanned by the columns of A as vectors in $\mathbb{F}^p$ (denoted $\text{col}(A)$), and the **row space** is the space spanned by the rows of A as vectors in $\mathbb{F}^q$ (denoted $\text{row}(A)$).

Notice that if we write $A = (\mathbf{c}_1 \mathbf{c}_2 \dots \mathbf{c}_q)$ where each $\mathbf{c}_i \in \mathbb{F}^p$ is the i th column of A , then we have

$$\begin{aligned}\text{im}(A) &= \{A\mathbf{v} : \mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{F}^q\} \\ &= \{v_1\mathbf{c}_1 + v_2\mathbf{c}_2 + \dots + v_q\mathbf{c}_q : v \in \mathbb{F}\} \\ &= \text{span}(\{\mathbf{c}_1, \mathbf{c}_2, \dots, \mathbf{c}_q\}) \\ &= \text{col}(A).\end{aligned}$$

So $\text{im}(A)$ is the span of the columns of A .

Fact. For any matrix A , we have $\dim(\text{row}(A)) = \dim(\text{col}(A)) = \text{rank}(A)$.

Matrix of a linear map

Theorem. Suppose $(V, \mathbb{F})$ is a vector space with basis B and finite dimension q , and $(W, \mathbb{F})$ is a vector space with basis C and finite dimension p . If $T : V \rightarrow W$ is a linear transformation, then there exists a unique matrix $A \in M_{p,q}(\mathbb{F})$ such that $A[\mathbf{v}]_B = [T(\mathbf{v})]_C$ for all $\mathbf{v} \in V$.

Proof. Let $B = \{\mathbf{v}_1, \dots, \mathbf{v}_q\}$. Consider the matrix

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} [T(\mathbf{v}_1)]_C & [T(\mathbf{v}_2)]_C & \dots & [T(\mathbf{v}_q)]_C \end{pmatrix}$$

whose columns are constructed by applying T to each basis B vector and finding the result's coordinate vector over C (so the (i, j) th entry of A is the i th coordinate of $T(\mathbf{v}_j)$ over C).

For any $\mathbf{v} \in V$, write $\mathbf{v} = \sum \lambda_i \mathbf{v}_i$ for some $\lambda_i \in \mathbb{F}$. Then since T and the act of taking coordinates are linear transformations,

$$A[\mathbf{v}]_B = A(\lambda_i)_{1 \leq i \leq q} = \sum_{i=1}^q \lambda_i [T(\mathbf{v}_i)]_C = \left[T \left(\sum_{i=1}^q \lambda_i \mathbf{v}_i \right) \right]_C = [T(\mathbf{v})]_C.$$

To see that the matrix A is unique, note that if there were some other matrix A' satisfying the requirements, then $A[\mathbf{v}]_B = A'[\mathbf{v}]_B$ for all $\mathbf{v} \in V$, meaning $(A - A')\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{0}$ for all $\mathbf{u} \in \mathbb{F}^q$, so $A - A' = \mathbf{0}$ and thus $A = A'$.

Matrix of a linear map

Corollary. Any matrix $A \in M_{p,q}(\mathbb{F})$ determines a unique linear map $T : V \rightarrow W$ given by $[T(\mathbf{v})]_C = A[\mathbf{v}]_B$ for all $\mathbf{v} \in V$.

Corollary. Given finite-dimensional vector spaces $(V, \mathbb{F})$ and $(W, \mathbb{F})$ with $\dim(V) = q$ and $\dim(W) = p$, we have $\mathcal{L}(V, W) \cong M_{p,q}(\mathbb{F})$.

Definition. Given finite-dimensional vector spaces $(V, \mathbb{F})$ and $(W, \mathbb{F})$ with bases B and C respectively, and a linear transformation $T : V \rightarrow W$, the **transformation matrix of T with respect to B and C** is denoted by $[T]_C^B$ and is the $\dim(W) \times \dim(V)$ matrix over $\mathbb{F}$ given by

$$[T]_C^B = ([T(\mathbf{v}_1)]_C \quad [T(\mathbf{v}_2)]_C \quad \dots \quad [T(\mathbf{v}_q)]_C),$$

with the property that $[T(\mathbf{v})]_C = [T]_C^B[\mathbf{v}]_B$ for all $\mathbf{v} \in V$.

Definition. Given a vector space V with bases B and C , the transformation matrix $[\text{id}]_C^B$ is called the **change of basis matrix** from B to C .

In particular, for all $\mathbf{v} \in V$ we have $[\mathbf{v}]_C = [\text{id}]_C^B[\mathbf{v}]_B$.

Example – Identity map, nonstandard to standard bases

Exercise. Find the transformation matrix for the map $\text{id} : \mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow \mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R})$ with respect to the basis $B = \{2t^2 - t + 1, t^2 - t, 2t^2 - t + 2\}$ for the domain and the standard basis $\mathcal{S} = \{1, t, t^2\}$ for the codomain.

Solution. We want to find $[\text{id}]_S^B$ which is the matrix with columns given by $[\text{id}(p)]_S$ for each $p \in B$.

Here $\text{id}(2t^2 - t + 1) = (1)1 + (-1)t + (2)t^2$, so the corresponding coordinate vector is $[\text{id}(2t^2 - t + 1)]_S = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}$.

Similarly $[\text{id}(t^2 - t)]_S = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ -1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$ and $[\text{id}(2t^2 - t + 2)]_S = \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ -1 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}$.

Since each of these vectors is already their coordinate vector over the standard basis $\mathcal{S}$, we have

$$[\text{id}]_S^B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 2 \\ -1 & -1 & -1 \\ 2 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Example – Identity map, standard to nonstandard bases

Exercise. Find the transformation matrix for the map $\text{id} : \mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow \mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R})$ with respect to the standard basis $\mathcal{S} = \{1, t, t^2\}$ for the domain and the basis $B = \{2t^2 - t + 1, t^2 - t, 2t^2 - t + 2\}$ for the codomain.

Solution. We want to find $[\text{id}]_B^{\mathcal{S}}$ which is the matrix with columns given by $[\text{id}(p)]_B$ for each $p \in \mathcal{S}$. To find $[\text{id}(1)]_B$ we need to solve the equation $\text{id}(1) = 1 = \lambda_1(2t^2 - t + 1) + \lambda_2(t^2 - t) + \lambda_3(2t^2 - t + 2)$ for $\lambda_i \in \mathbb{R}$, which is a system of equations with corresponding matrix $\left(\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 \\ -1 & -1 & -1 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 & 2 & 0 \end{array} \right)$.

For $[\text{id}(t)]_B$ and $[\text{id}(t^2)]_B$ we need to solve similar systems, except with the last column being replaced by $\mathbf{e}_2$ and $\mathbf{e}_3$ respectively. We can solve all three systems simultaneously by row-reducing the augmented matrix

$$\left(\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ -1 & -1 & -1 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 & 2 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right) \sim \left(\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 0 & -1 & 2 & 2 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & -2 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 1 & -1 & -1 \end{array} \right).$$

The columns to the right of the bar are precisely the coordinate vectors, so

$$[\text{id}]_B^{\mathcal{S}} = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 2 & 2 \\ 0 & -2 & -1 \\ 1 & -1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Transformation matrix inverses

Notice that in the previous example, the way $[\text{id}]_B^S$ was constructed is the same method as is used to produce the inverse of a matrix. Indeed, we can check that $[\text{id}]_B^S = ([\text{id}]_S^B)^{-1}$.

Lemma. Given a vector space V with bases B and C , the change of basis matrix from C to B is the inverse of the change of basis matrix from B to C , that is, $[\text{id}]_B^C = ([\text{id}]_C^B)^{-1}$.

Proof. For any $\mathbf{v} \in V$, we have

$$[\mathbf{v}]_C = [\text{id}]_C^B[\mathbf{v}]_B = [\text{id}]_C^B([\text{id}]_B^C[\mathbf{v}]_C) = ([\text{id}]_C^B[\text{id}]_B^C)[\mathbf{v}]_C.$$

As this is true for all $\mathbf{v} \in V$, we have $[\text{id}]_C^B[\text{id}]_B^C = I$, so $[\text{id}]_B^C = ([\text{id}]_C^B)^{-1}$.

More generally we have the following (proven after the next theorem).

Lemma. Given a linear transformation $T : V \rightarrow W$ for vector spaces V and W with respective bases B and C , if T is invertible then $[T^{-1}]_B^C = ([T]_C^B)^{-1}$.

Corollary. Given any transformation matrix A for a linear map T , the matrix A is invertible if and only if the function T is invertible.

Corollary. The space of bijective linear maps from vector spaces $(V, \mathbb{F})$ to $(W, \mathbb{F})$ with dimension n is isomorphic to $\text{GL}(n, \mathbb{F})$.

Example – Identity map, nonstandard to nonstandard bases

Exercise. Find the transformation matrix for the map $\text{id} : \mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow \mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R})$ with respect to the basis $C = \{t^2 - 1, 2t^2 - t - 2, 2t^2\}$ for the domain and the basis $B = \{2t^2 - t + 1, t^2 - t, 2t^2 - t + 2\}$ for the codomain.

Solution. We want to find $[\text{id}]_B^C$ which is the matrix with columns given by $[\text{id}(p)]_B$ for each $p \in C$. To find $[\text{id}(t^2 - 1)]_B$ we need to solve the equation

$$\lambda_1(2t^2 - t + 1) + \lambda_2(t^2 - t) + \lambda_3(2t^2 - t + 2) = t^2 - 1$$

for $\lambda_i \in \mathbb{R}$, and likewise for $[\text{id}(2t^2 - t - 2)]_B$ and $[\text{id}(2t^2)]_B$. We can solve all three implied systems of linear equations simultaneously by row-reducing the augmented matrix

$$\left(\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 2 & -1 & -2 & 0 \\ -1 & -1 & -1 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 & 2 & 1 & 2 & 2 \end{array} \right) \sim \left(\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 0 & 3 & 4 & 4 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -1 & 0 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -2 & -3 & -2 \end{array} \right).$$

The columns to the right of the bar are precisely the coordinate vectors, so

$$[\text{id}]_B^C = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 4 & 4 \\ -1 & 0 & -2 \\ -2 & -3 & -2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Transformation matrix multiplication

Notice that in the prior example, the result $[\text{id}]_B^C$ is equivalent to the matrix product $[\text{id}]_B^S[\text{id}]_S^C$ where $S = \{1, t, t^2\}$ is the standard basis for $\mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R})$.

A more general result related to this is given below.

Lemma. Given two linear transformations $S : U \rightarrow V$ and $T : V \rightarrow W$ for vector spaces U , V , and W with bases B , C , and D respectively, we have $[T \circ S]_D^B = [T]_D^C[S]_C^B$.

Proof. Note that for all $\mathbf{u} \in U$,

$$\begin{aligned} [T \circ S]_D^B[\mathbf{u}]_B &= [T \circ S(\mathbf{u})]_D \\ &= [T(S(\mathbf{u}))]_D \\ &= [T]_D^C[S(\mathbf{u})]_C \\ &= [T]_D^C[S]_C^B[\mathbf{u}]_B. \end{aligned}$$

Since this is true for all $\mathbf{u} \in U$, we must have $[T \circ S]_D^B = [T]_D^C[S]_C^B$.

Corollary. For invertible T , we find $[T^{-1}]_B^C[T]_C^B = [T^{-1} \circ T]_B^B = [\text{id}]_B^B = I$.

This proves the previous result $[T^{-1}]_B^C = ([T]_C^B)^{-1}$ for any invertible T .

Example – Arbitrary map, standard to standard bases

Exercise. Find the transformation matrix for the map $T : \mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^3$

given by $T(p) = \begin{pmatrix} p(0) \\ p(1) \\ p(2) \end{pmatrix}$ (with respect to the standard bases).

Solution. Writing $\mathcal{S} = \{1, t, t^2\}$ for the standard basis of $\mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R})$ and $\mathcal{S}' = \{\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2, \mathbf{e}_3\}$ for the standard basis of $\mathbb{R}^3$, we want to find $[T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^{\mathcal{S}}$, which is the matrix with columns given by $[T(p)]_{\mathcal{S}'}$ for each $p \in \mathcal{S}$.

Since $T(1) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$, $T(t) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}$, and $T(t^2) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ 4 \end{pmatrix}$, and each of these vectors is already their coordinate vector over the standard basis $\mathcal{S}'$, we have

$$[T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^{\mathcal{S}} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 & 4 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Example – Arbitrary map, nonstandard to standard bases

Exercise. Find the transformation matrix for $T : \mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^3$ given by

$$T(p) = \begin{pmatrix} p(0) \\ p(1) \\ p(2) \end{pmatrix} \text{ with respect to the basis } B = \{t - 1, t^2 - 2, t^2 - t\} \text{ for}$$

$\mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R})$ and the standard basis $\mathcal{S}'$ for $\mathbb{R}^3$.

Solution. Here $T(t - 1) = \begin{pmatrix} -1 \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$, $T(t^2 - 2) = \begin{pmatrix} -2 \\ -1 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}$, $T(t^2 - t) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}$,

and each of these vectors is already their coordinate vector over the standard basis $\mathcal{S}'$, so

$$[T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^B = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & -2 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 1 & 2 & 2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Alternatively, writing $\mathcal{S} = \{1, t, t^2\}$ for the standard basis for $\mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R})$,

$$[T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^B = [T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^{\mathcal{S}} [\text{id}]_{\mathcal{S}}^B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} -1 & -2 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & -2 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 1 & 2 & 2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Example – Arbitrary map, nonstandard to nonstandard

Exercise. Find the transformation matrix for $T : \mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^3$ given by

$$T(p) = \begin{pmatrix} p(0) \\ p(1) \\ p(2) \end{pmatrix} \text{ with respect to the basis } B = \{t - 1, t^2 - 2, t^2 - t\} \text{ for}$$

$$\mathcal{P}_2(\mathbb{R}) \text{ and the basis } C = \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ -1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 2 \\ -1 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \text{ for } \mathbb{R}^3.$$

Solution. From the previous example, $[T]_{S'}^B = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & -2 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 1 & 2 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$ where S' is

the standard basis for $\mathbb{R}^3$. Now we want each column's coordinates over the basis C . As before, we want to take the right half of the row-reduced matrix

$$\left(\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 2 & -1 & -2 & 0 \\ -1 & -1 & -1 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 2 & 1 & 2 & 1 & 2 & 2 \end{array} \right) \sim \left(\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 0 & 3 & 4 & 4 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -1 & 0 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -2 & -3 & -2 \end{array} \right).$$

Alternatively,

$$[T]_C^B = [\text{id}]_C^{S'} [T]_{S'}^B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 2 \\ -1 & -1 & -1 \\ 2 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}^{-1} \begin{pmatrix} -1 & -2 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 1 & 2 & 2 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 4 & 4 \\ -1 & 0 & -2 \\ -2 & -3 & -2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Change of basis formula

The previous examples and theorems combine to give the following formula.

Theorem. (Change of basis formula)

Given a linear transformation $T : V \rightarrow W$ between vector spaces V and W with respective standard bases $\mathcal{S}$ and $\mathcal{S}'$ and given bases B and C , the transformation matrix of T with respect to B and C is given by the formula

$$[T]_C^B = [\text{id}_W]_C^{\mathcal{S}'} [T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^{\mathcal{S}} [\text{id}_V]_S^B.$$

This is sometimes represented by a so-called commutative diagram:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} \text{(basis } B) \ V & \xrightarrow{[T]_C^B} & W \text{ (basis } C) \\ \downarrow [\text{id}_V]_S^B & & \downarrow [\text{id}_W]_{\mathcal{S}'}^C \\ \text{(basis } \mathcal{S}) \ V & \xrightarrow{[T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^{\mathcal{S}}} & W \text{ (basis } \mathcal{S}') \end{array}$$

Notice that while $[T]_C^B$ might be hard to find in general, the matrices $[\text{id}_V]_S^B$ and $[T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^{\mathcal{S}}$ are relatively easy to find, as is $[\text{id}_W]_{\mathcal{S}'}^C$, whose inverse is $[\text{id}_W]_C^{\mathcal{S}'}$.

Sometimes it is even easier to find $[T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^{\mathcal{S}}$ (like in the previous example), in which case we can just use the formula $[T]_C^B = [\text{id}_W]_C^{\mathcal{S}'} [T]_{\mathcal{S}'}^{\mathcal{S}}$.

Example – Change of basis formula

Exercise. Find the transformation matrix for the map $T : \mathbb{R}^3 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ given by $T(\mathbf{v}) = \begin{pmatrix} v_1 - v_3 \\ 2v_1 + v_2 \end{pmatrix}$ where $\mathbf{v} = (v_1 \ v_2 \ v_3)^T$ with respect to the bases

$$B = \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \text{ for } \mathbb{R}^3 \text{ and } C = \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ -2 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} -1 \\ 3 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \text{ for } \mathbb{R}^2.$$

Solution. We want to find $[T]_C^B = [\text{id}]_C^{S'} [T]_{S'}^S [\text{id}]_S^B$ where

$$[\text{id}]_S^B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, [\text{id}]_{S'}^C = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ -2 & 3 \end{pmatrix}, \text{ and } [T]_{S'}^S = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 2 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Here $[T]_{S'}^S [\text{id}]_S^B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 3 & 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$ and $[\text{id}]_C^{S'} = ([\text{id}]_{S'}^C)^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, thus

$$[T]_C^B = [\text{id}]_C^{S'} [T]_{S'}^S [\text{id}]_S^B = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 3 & 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 6 & 2 & 3 \\ 5 & 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Alternatively, take the right half of the row-reduced matrix

$$\left(\begin{array}{cc|ccc} 1 & -1 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ -2 & 3 & 3 & 2 & 3 \end{array} \right) \sim \left(\begin{array}{cc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 6 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 & 5 & 2 & 3 \end{array} \right).$$